

Paper 6: The Culture Industry

There are a number of profound implications to Horkheimer and Adorno's scathing attack on mass media and entertainment. At its heart, it is a piece detailing the hidden mechanisms of propaganda and complicity. On the topic of fascism, while it is commonplace to direct our attention to what Foucault called the repressive state apparatus – things like the secret police, restrictions on civil liberties, the explicit surveillance state – critical theory encourages us to never discount the power of the ideological apparatus. Think more Discipline and not Punishment. The surveillance state which arises as the result of people's behavior living and operating within the panopticon, a situation that is highly relevant when discussing the culture industry. It is also an issue that translates especially well when discussing the ways in which liberal democracy aid and abet the conditions that are conducive to fascism.

It doesn't take a media expert to notice all the ways in which Adorno and Horkheimer's critiques manifest in reality. Indeed, their first observation is on the pervading presence of monotony within the film and television industries. According to them, "culture today is infecting everything with sameness." Just as the architecture of the physical world is characterized more and more by indistinguishable sameness, the creations of human imagination are similarly colored in an uninspired grayscale. However, what Adorno and Horkheimer want their readers to understand is that this is no mere coincidence. In other words, there is a very deliberate reason why nowadays, everything seems to be subject to enfranchisement. Originality

is on its way out and everyone seems to be growing tired of the cinematic universe ploy. Even still, the relationship is more complicated than that. Hollywood is engaged in a never-ending cycle of innovative self-destruction. “Unending sameness also governs the relationship to the past. What is new in the phase of mass culture compared to that of late liberalism is the exclusion of the new... That is why there is incessant talk of ideas, novelty and surprises, of what is both totally familiar and has never existed before” (pg. 106). In essence, the culture industry is aware of the fact that it exists on a ticking time bomb, the inevitable result of capital’s need to tear down what it produces in order to fuel its reproduction. It explains why at an awards show like the Oscars, a film like Bong Joon Ho’s “Parasite”, a very class conscious film by a very class conscious director, can receive so much acclaim. It makes us feel good that a film with so many progressive and critical motifs is well received in the halls of power. “Something is provided for everyone so that no one can escape...” (pg. 97) Consequently, we are made more content with the status quo.

Yet the culture industry is not infallible. The cracks begin to show. According to Horkheimer and Adorno, if the social tendencies of this era are primarily dictated by the board chairmen of steel, oil, and energy, it is necessarily the case that the culture monopolies ride their coattails (pg. 96). “They have to keep in with the true wielders of power, to ensure that their sphere of mass society, the specific product of which still has too much of cozy liberalism and Jewish intellectualism about it, is not subjected to a series of purges.” This dependence on power ultimately leads to the consolidatory effect in capitalism. At the level of substance, “everything is so tightly clustered that the concentration of intellect reaches a level where it overflows the demarcations between company names and technical sectors.” Where there were maybe a hundred media companies, news outlets, and banks fifty years ago, now there are five. Even so,

they are basically the same five companies in terms of what they produce, but the culture industry leads us to believe they offer clearly distinct services based on what are truly asinine differences. For example, all the streaming services out right now effectively have the same rights to each other's IP's, which is why we see certain films bounce around between Netflix, HBO, and Disney. In what has become a clear power play, and likely a wearing down of the culture industry's illusions, Paramount Skydance's move to acquire Warner Brothers at the behest of owner Larry Ellison is probably the best case for what the industry has been all about for decades. It has only moved from operating in the shadows to being brought to the light due in part to a social climate that is more tolerable to fascistic behavior.

I guess this leaves me with some questions mostly concerning the need for subterfuge with the culture industry. Horkheimer and Adorno write that in their time, the ruler no longer says, "either you think as I do or you die." Instead, he opts for: "You are free not to think as I do; your life, your property – all that you shall keep. But from this day on you will be a stranger among us" (pg. 105). Do we take this to be the primary *modus operandi* of the authoritarian today? And on the topic of media, what is left that can truly be considered avantgarde, the adversary to the culture industry? Are we all better off watching experimental and indie films? And if there is a genre of film that is least susceptible to being captured by the industry, what do we take it to be?